

CDN Incident Alert: 0052. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** DE Russian State Media Promotes WABEO's Parallel Vote Tabulation: A Potential Spark For Election Conspiracies

28/02/2025

Summary

- WABEO is a private, pay-to-participate "election observation" project that our investigation indicates is lacking key safeguards found in official monitoring, such as transparent oversight of volunteer recruitment and open result certification. The group presents its work as "legally binding" and "court-proof," although recognized German electoral law designates that results must be certified by election boards, not private initiatives.
- Russian state media (RT) interviewed WABEO's founders before the election, amplifying doubts about Germany's election procedures and referencing unverified claims of "ghost constituencies."
- WABEO's messaging is promoted on conspiracy-oriented Telegram channels, appealing to existing distrust in democratic processes. Some messages have been viewed more than 60,000 times.
- Recommendations: Investigate WABEO's funding and volunteer process, any discernible financial or infrastructural ties to Kremlin state assets, and clarify the distinction between official and private electoral audits.

Incident

Leading up to the German election, WABEO (run by the association *Bürger für Deutschland e. V.* [Citizens for Germany]) launched its private election-monitoring campaign, inviting volunteers to collect and report vote tallies through its proprietary app (1). The initiative has not publicly declared its funding sources as far as we have ascertained. This initiative was advertised on anti-government and conspiracy-focused Telegram channels, positioning WABEO as an alternative to official election boards (e.g. 2). Russian state media coverage further elevated WABEO's narrative, reinforcing skepticism toward Germany's democratic procedures (3, 4).

Narrative

Meta narrative: Potential electoral irregularities undermine trust in official voting procedures;
Sub-narratives: *Bürger für Deutschland e. V.* fosters parallel election results to question the legitimacy of the German government; WABEO's purported "legally binding" findings circumvent standard certification processes; Amplification by Russian state media feeds existing doubts about Germany's democratic institutions.

Impact

- WABEO's volunteer-driven reports, if widely circulated, risk introducing confusion or disputing official results at a critical moment in the process.
- On Telegram, LION Media's promotion of WABEO garnered more than 60,000 views, suggesting notable reach among conspiracy-minded audiences.
- RT's coverage aligns with broader attempts to spotlight narratives of election fraud or system failure in Western democracies.
- Final impact is yet to be determined, particularly increased distrust of democratic processes.

Key Objectives and Behaviours

- Objective 1: [Cultivate Support for Initiative](#) - RT tries to give them legitimacy by promoting them.
Objective 2: [Subvert](#) - Challenge and undermine the official election results.
- [Mobile App Asset](#) - WABEO produced and promoted an app to collect and aggregate data.
 - [Create Community or Sub-Group](#): WABEO represents an attempt to establish a community of "election observers" via pay-to-participate initiative.
 - [Prepare Fundraising Campaigns](#). Promotion via RT and Telegram channels to large audiences could encourage greater financial investment.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

- Educate the public on the difference between official and private election-monitoring processes;
- Investigate WABEO's funding and the technical integrity of its reporting mechanism;

- Encourage transparent labeling and public disclaimers on social platforms hosting WABEO content, underscoring its unofficial status;

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Germany Elections, Parallel Vote Counting, Conspiracy Theories	In text.	Joe Ondrak, Alliance4Europe.	Telegram, Websites.	